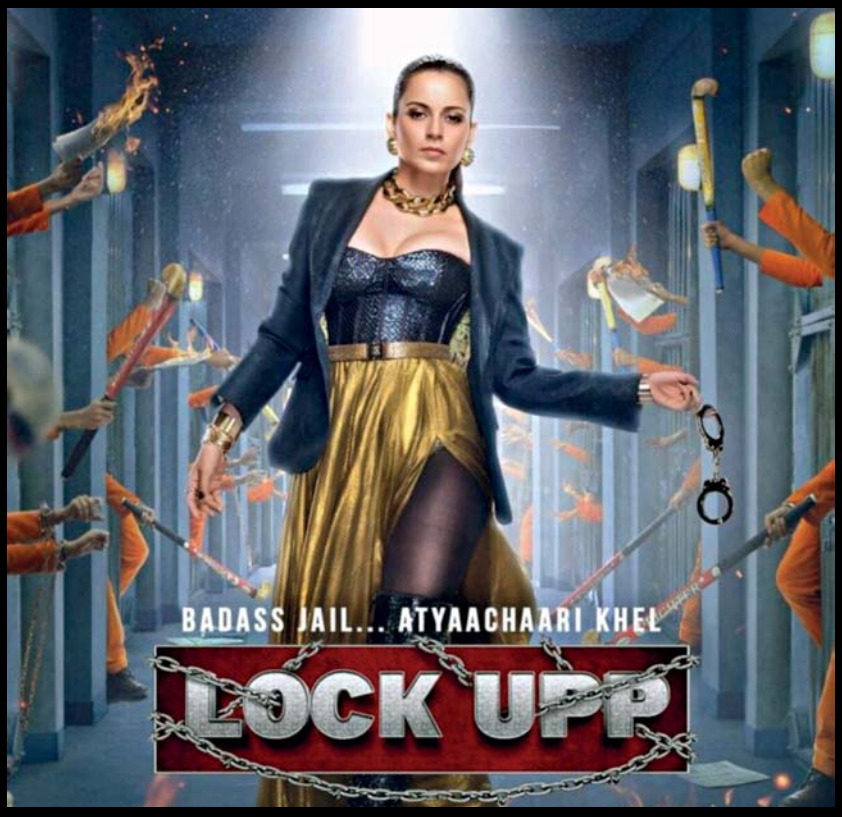






REALITY TELEVISION

REALITY CHECK

AS REALITY SHOWS BECOME POPULAR AGAIN, WE SEE THEM TRYING TO FIND SOME UNITY IN DIVERSITY

Reality shows, if seen through a generous, unironic eye, are petri dishes of the things that make up our nation. A microcosmic exaggeration of who we are. An insistence on "diversity" gets built into the narrative, whose increasing popularity streaming platforms are lapping up—*Big Boss* (2006—) on Disney+ Hotstar, *Shark Tank India* (2021—) on SonyLIV, *Lock Upp* (2022—) on ALTBalaji and MX Player, *Dance India Dance* (2009—) on Zee5.

Was it a coincidence, then, that the first two contestants of the recently released *Shark Tank India*—a reality show where budding entrepreneurs make business pitches to a panel of five investors or 'sharks'—came from two opposite ends of the country: Bhavnagar in Gujarat and Darjeeling in West Bengal? Guided by the belief that the post-liberalised Indian landscape is united by an entrepreneurial spirit, the show seems to suggest that a product can be local but the customer is always floating in a "glocalised" ether. Everything, from potato chips to Indori poha, Kerala banana chips, Kunafa and, of course, Maggi, is being sold in Aizawl, Shillong, Pathankot and Nellore. (That *Shark Tank India* takes place entirely in Hindi also shows the limitation of this tapestried project.)

But sometimes, like in *Lock Upp*, a more brutal cousin of *Big Boss* where controversial contestants are locked up in a jail-like set for 10 weeks, it is not the geographic diversity as much as the spectrum of political persuasions that is used to convey this stitched portrait—the comedian Munawar Faruqui's *namaz*, actor Karanvir Bohra's *puja*, politician Chakrapani Maharaj's saffron-clad *gau-mutra* parties, Poonam Pandey's oomph,